Other
Newsmakers

AMIT SHAH 61
Home Minister

Way back in 2006, then prime minister Dr Manmohan Singh had identified Maoism as "the single biggest internal security challenge faced by the country". Two decades had to pass before its end was in sight, and it was Union home minister Amit Shah who made it his remit to preside over its dismantling. A movement that once held sway over 160 districts in the country has now been worn down to 11. Only three contiguous districts in Chhattisgarh—Sukma, Bijapur and Narayanpur—remain in the 'most affected' list, according to the October 2025 assessment by the Ministry of Home Affairs (MHA). Clearly, cutting the legs off the Maoist movement has been Shah's crowning achievement in 2025, though political analysts will also point to how the BJP's master election strategist shepherded the party to wins in the two big states to go to elections in the year—Delhi and Bihar.

Early in 2024, Shah had declared that Maoism would be wiped out in India by March 31, 2026, setting a deadline for the security agencies. On cue, around then, the security forces launched aggressive operations against the Maoists in Chhattisgarh, the state that remained their citadel after the movement had weakened in the contiguous states of Odisha, Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Madhya Pradesh and Maharashtra. Shah has dedicated a lot of time and effort to the issue. "I held 85 meetings in the last six years solely on the Maoism issue...some of them went on from morning to evening," he told INDIA TODAY earlier in an interview. It clearly sent a message to the rank and file, that this was a fight to the finish, that there would be no backing out. The strategising was backed by more boots on the ground and added resources in the form of weapons, drones, armoured vehicles, as well as investment in tech and human intelligence-gathering. The number of fortified police stations in Maoist areas went up from 66 in 2014 to 612 in 2024. Most importantly, force commanders were given a free hand to take risks and launch operations. The change of government in Chhattisgarh in December 2023—the Bhupesh Baghel-led Congress regime making way for a Centre-friendly saffron dispensation—was also a big factor in the success, say intelligence sources.

The scale of the anti-Maoist operations was massive—in Chhattisgarh alone, the rebels held 18,000 sq. km in 2014; it's now some 3,000 sq. km. Likewise, the number of security personnel (509) and civilians (1,495) killed has come down by over 70 per cent decade on decade.

The coordinated efforts began to show results by 2024, with the security forces 'neutralising' 217 Maoists in Chhattisgarh that year. In 2025, by November-end, this number stood at 234.

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Safe and Secure

- **Amit Shah had set Mar. 31, 2026 as deadline to "make India Naxal-free"; indications are that he has largely succeeded**
- **Multi-Agency Centre (MAC) set up for seamless inter-agency responses to terrorism, organised crime, cyber threats**
- **Security lapses led to the attacks on tourists in Pahalgam in April, Red Fort car bomb explosion in November**

Those eliminated include many of the CPI (Maoist) top leadership, including general secretary Basavaraju and four other central committee members. Meanwhile, Madvi Hidma, one of the most adept field commanders on the Maoist side, was killed by the Andra Pradesh police in an encounter. With the movement suddenly rudderless, there were many surrenders, including by a group led by senior leader Bhupathi in Maharashtra, and another one led by Rupesh in Chhattisgarh. Over 800 Maoists surrendered in Chhattisgarh in 2024, with the number almost doubling (1,500-plus) in 2025, suggesting the purge has had an effect.

With the Maoist movement on the slide, the country's longest-serving home minister (Shah has held the post since May 30, 2019) should get a satisfactory rating from most quarters. There were a couple of blips, from the security lapses that led to the attacks on tourists in Pahalgam in April 2025 to the car bomb explosion near the Red Fort in November, but overall, it was a year of incremental pluses for the man considered the second most powerful BJP leader in the country. ■